Pembrolizumab 400 mg · every 6 weeks · lung cancer

Pembrolizumab 400 mg is given as a drip over about 30 minutes on Day 1 every 6 weeks (42 days). The hospital visit is longer because of checks and preparation. After complete surgery and platinum chemotherapy, the adjuvant course lasts up to 12 months. For metastatic cancer, treatment continues while it remains helpful and tolerable; the team may consider stopping after 24 months of sustained response without progression, or continuing when appropriate.

Source reconciled; independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending. Selected effects; not a complete medicine leaflet.

A picture of side effects

Numbered symptom boxes connect to the anatomical illustration. The medicine responsible may be uncertain; report the symptom.

1 Hormones / nervous system

Pembrolizumab

Severe headache, confusion, weakness, dizziness or marked thirst need prompt advice.

3 Heart

Pembrolizumab

Chest pain, racing heartbeat or fainting needs urgent assessment.

5 Kidneys

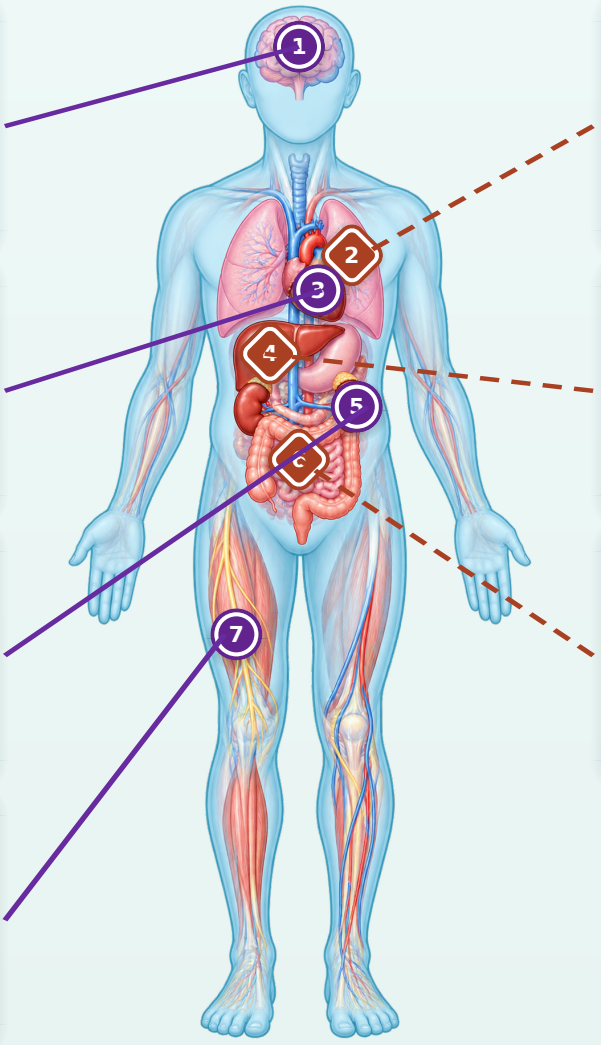
Pembrolizumab

Report much less urine, new swelling or a change in kidney tests.

7 Skin / muscles

Pembrolizumab

Spreading rash, blisters, severe weakness or muscle pain needs prompt review.



2 Lungs

Pembrolizumab

New cough or breathlessness can signal inflammation or another urgent cause.

4 Liver

Pembrolizumab

Yellow eyes/skin or dark urine may signal inflammation; tests also check the liver.

6 Bowel

Pembrolizumab

New or persistent diarrhoea, blood in stools or severe tummy pain needs urgent advice.

Selected effects, not every possible effect or a prediction. Blood-count, skin and line markers are schematic. Number and text carry meaning; colour is decorative.

Contact the oncology team immediately for new or worsening breathlessness, chest pain, persistent diarrhoea, severe tummy pain, yellow skin/eyes, much less urine, severe headache, marked weakness, confusion, unusual thirst or passing much more urine, or a spreading/blistering rash. For severe breathing difficulty, collapse, seizure or other immediately dangerous symptoms, seek emergency care. Do not wait for the next infusion.

Your treatment, at home.

Important medicine-specific effects

Pembrolizumab

- Immune inflammation of lungs, bowel, liver, kidneys, hormone glands, skin, heart and nervous system
- Infusion reactions
- Some effects need steroids, hospital care or long-term hormone replacement
- Effects may start after the final dose

Surgery, radiation and monitoring: open the whole-treatment map or scan the QR.

Make the plan practical

Sickness medicines

Pembrolizumab alone has a minimal risk of causing sickness. Routine anti-sickness medicines or infusion premedicines are not usually needed; your team can prescribe symptom relief if required.

Immune alert card

Carry your alert card during treatment and afterwards. Show it when seeking urgent care; symptoms can be mistaken for an infection or an ordinary stomach upset.

Hormones and steroids

Some immune effects need steroids or hormone replacement. Follow the prescribed plan and do not stop steroids suddenly. Ask for help if symptoms worsen or you cannot take essential medicines.

Pregnancy and breastfeeding

Discuss pregnancy, fertility and breastfeeding before treatment. Use effective contraception during treatment and for at least four months after the last dose. If pregnancy is possible or occurs, contact your oncology team promptly.

Emergency: 112 / 999. Severe breathing difficulty, collapse, seizure or severe chest pain needs emergency help.

Contact oncology immediately for temperature ≥37.5°C or ≤36°C, shivering or suddenly feeling unwell, even with a normal temperature. Follow your own hospital's instructions. If you cannot reach the team, seek urgent medical assessment.

YOUR ONCOLOGY TEAM · DAYTIME

Insert numbers here

Acute Oncology Service

YOUR ONCOLOGY TEAM · OUT OF HOURS

Insert numbers here

Ask for medical oncology

EVENINGS / OVERNIGHT

Your out-of-hours pathway / nearest ED

Other hospitals: use the numbers your team provides.

Complete reference, visual timeline and passport

https://sactcheck.com/patient/00558/

Sources and review status are available online. Follow your own prescription and hospital instructions.